unidimensional. It will require sagacious leadership. As Amit Shah put it to a 2017 meeting of intellectuals in Palampur, 'The Congress had many people of many ideologies. They didn't have any principles, only the aim of somehow capturing power. That is why later, many parties at different times kept leaving it.'[66] This is precisely the problem the BJP is likely to face as it expands. As this book has documented, it is now as large a social hold-all tent as the Congress was at its peak. Managing the contradictions of this expansion and aligning them with its own ideological principles will hold the key to its future.

Challenge 4: The Question of Leadership after Modi

Prime Minister Modi has undoubtedly been the catalyst and harbinger of the new BJP. Election after election has revealed that his personal popularity with voters remains undiminished. Survey after survey has shown that he continues to bring a huge premium to the party. Modi (born in 1950) remains the driving engine of his party's political juggernaut. Therefore, given that the party has radically shape-shifted on Modi's watch, the ability of his eventual successor to manage the system that Modi–Shah built will be critical. Modi has several years of active politics ahead of him. The big question for the BJP is: who can lead it next?

Amit Shah (born 1964) is fourteen years younger than Modi, and only six years older than the Congress's Rahul Gandhi. Not only did Shah co-create the BJP's new organisational structures under Modi, putting his stamp on its revamp, he has been the face of some of the party's biggest ideological projects in governance: revoking Article 370 on Kashmir and ushering in the CAA. He has also been the BJP's most prominent orator, after Modi, since 2016. What could a possible Shah prime ministership look like? Would it be ideologically harder on Hindutva? And would it garner the same national voter enthusiasm that Modi evokes? Shah declared in a piece he wrote on the Modi government completing its sixth year in power that the 'BJP-led central government has implemented every promise in its manifesto'. He went on to list these promises: the repeal of Article 370, CAA, the Triple Talaq law and 'paving the way